

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Schools of Buddhism - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Schools of Buddhism

REFRESHED TEACHING NAVIGATION — BASIC/CORE FIRST

01

CONTEMPORARY-ANCHOR DISCIPLINE

Contemporary-anchor discipline: □□ Inference: The event can frame

02

MASTER DISTINCTION GATEWAY

Master verdict: Buddhism is a family of anti-substantialist, causally

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Schools of Buddhism - Learner-v2 Source-Complete Learning Session

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol - [CORE ANSWER]

Attempt each item before reading its key. Answer placement is balanced, deterministic and non-patterned using a stable topic seed. across all forty-eight diagnostics.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

1. Which formulation best expresses the general principle of Pratītyasamutpāda?

A. A creator initiates the first member of every causal series. B. Conditioned phenomena arise and cease with their supporting conditions. C. Every effect already exists materially in its cause. D. An eternal self coordinates otherwise disconnected events.

Answer: B. Conditioned phenomena arise and cease with their supporting conditions.

Explanation: The formula “this being, that arises; with the cessation of this, that ceases” states conditionality. It avoids eternalism because no conditioned entity is immutable, and avoids annihilationism because events arise in ordered dependence rather than from nothing.

2. In the Four Noble Truths, Pratītyasamutpāda most directly explains the relation between:

A. right speech and right livelihood. B. the origin of duḥkha and its possible cessation. C. perception and inference. D. Buddha and Saṅgha.

Answer: B. The origin of duḥkha and its possible cessation.

Explanation: Dependent origination supplies the causal grammar of the second and third truths: suffering arises because relevant conditions operate, and it ceases when those conditions-especially ignorance, craving and clinging-are removed.

3. Which sequence correctly presents the first four nidānas?

A. saṃskāra -> avidyā -> nāma-rūpa -> vijñāna B. vijñāna -> avidyā -> nāma-rūpa -> saṃskāra C. avidyā -> vijñāna -> saṃskāra -> nāma-rūpa D. avidyā -> saṃskāra -> vijñāna -> nāma-rūpa

Answer: D. Avidyā -> saṃskāra -> vijñāna -> nāma-rūpa.

Explanation: Ignorance conditions formations, formations condition consciousness, and consciousness conditions name-and-form. Confusing saṃskāra and vijñāna is a frequent factual trap.

4. Which sequence correctly completes the twelve-link chain after vedanā?

A. tṛṣṇā -> upādāna -> bhava -> jāti -> jarā-maraṇa B. tṛṣṇā -> bhava -> upādāna -> jāti -> jarā-maraṇa C. upādāna -> tṛṣṇā -> jāti -> bhava -> jarā-maraṇa D. bhava -> tṛṣṇā -> upādāna -> jarā-maraṇa -> jāti

Answer: A. Tṛṣṇā -> upādāna -> bhava -> jāti -> jarā-maraṇa.

Explanation: Feeling conditions craving, craving clinging, clinging becoming, becoming birth, and birth ageing-and-death. The practical intervention point is crucial: feeling need not automatically harden into craving.

5. Why does dependent origination not imply fatalism?

A. Because altering conditions can interrupt the production of suffering. B. Because an unconditioned self can leave the causal order. C. Because every link must unfold identically in every person. D. Because karmic effects occur without causes.

Answer: A. Because altering conditions can interrupt the production of suffering.

Explanation: Conditionality makes practice meaningful. Ethics, mindfulness and insight change the causal environment; therefore the chain is explanatory and soteriological, not a fixed destiny.

6. The most defensible route from dependent origination to Kṣaṇikavāda is:

A. only what is permanent can produce a novel effect. B. causal series require an unchanging substratum. C. conditional impermanence plus the argument from causal efficacy supports moment-specific existence. D. dependence immediately proves that every event lasts exactly one measurable instant.

Answer: C. Conditional impermanence plus the argument from causal efficacy supports moment-specific existence.

Explanation: Pratītyasamutpāda directly establishes conditioned impermanence. Strict momentariness requires the added *arthakriyā* argument that real causal operation belongs to a determinate, changing phase.

7. Arthakriyākāritva means:

A. recognition by an enduring subject. B. membership in a real universal. C. correspondence between a word and an eternal meaning. D. capacity to perform an effective causal function.

Answer: D. Capacity to perform an effective causal function.

Explanation: Dignāga-Dharmakīrti traditions connect reality with causal efficacy. Since unique particulars alone produce effects, the criterion also supports their momentariness.

8. In the Buddhist simultaneity/succession dilemma, a wholly permanent cause is problematic because:

A. it would become a universal. B. it must be imperceptible. C. unchanged complete power gives no reason for delayed or successive production. D. it cannot possess qualities.

Answer: C. Unchanged complete power gives no reason for delayed or successive production.

Explanation: If the power is complete, the effect should occur immediately or continuously. If the cause gains a new operative power later, it has changed and is not wholly permanent.

9. What is the Buddhist response when Nyāya says a permanent cause waits for sahakārin auxiliary conditions?

A. If auxiliaries alter causal capacity, the operative complex is not wholly unchanged; if not, delay remains unexplained. B. Auxiliary conditions are always illusions. C. Permanent substances exist but cannot be known. D. Every cause and effect is simultaneous.

Answer: A. If auxiliaries alter causal capacity, the operative complex is not wholly unchanged; if not, delay remains unexplained.

Explanation: The reply targets explanatory work. Either the auxiliary contributes a difference, undermining strict permanence of the operative cause, or it contributes none, leaving delayed action mysterious.

10. Santāna is best understood as:

A. the final destruction of all causal relations. B. a causally connected continuum of numerically distinct moments. C. an eternal universal instantiated in persons. D. a subtle permanent soul concealed beneath momentary states.

Answer: B. A causally connected continuum of numerically distinct moments.

Explanation: *Santāna* preserves transmission, regularity and practical identity without numerical sameness. No-self denies a substance-bearer, not causal continuity.

11. Which statement best captures the Buddhist account of memory under momentariness?

A. Memory is impossible and only appears to occur. B. One permanent cognition survives from experience to recollection. C. Memory is supplied by a creator to each mental stream. D. An experience conditions a disposition that is transmitted and later produces recollection.

Answer: D. An experience conditions a disposition that is transmitted and later produces recollection.

Explanation: Sautrāntika uses traces or seeds, while Yogācāra systematizes their preservation through *ālaya-vijñāna*. The account explains causal transmission without an enduring experiencer.

12. Nyāya's strongest pressure on the Buddhist memory theory is that:

A. memory contains no past-directed content. B. all recognition is inference from universals. C. "I experienced this" seems to require one subject owning both experience and recollection. D. causal continuity is impossible between moments.

Answer: C. "I experienced this" seems to require one subject owning both experience and recollection.

Explanation: The Buddhist stream theory explains why information reappears, but Nyāya asks whether it explains first-person appropriation. The Buddhist reply treats ownership as constructed within an integrated causal continuum.

13. Which set contains only the five skandhas?

A. *buddhi, ahaṃkāra, manas, tanmātra, puruṣa* B. *rūpa, ātman, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna* C. *dravya, guṇa, karma, sāmānya, viśeṣa* D. *rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna*

Answer: D. Rūpa, vedanā, saṃjñā, saṃskāra, vijñāna.

Explanation: These are form, feeling, recognition, formations and consciousness. Buddhism finds no permanent self as one aggregate, their total, or their independent owner.

14. The Milinda-pañha chariot analogy primarily establishes that:

A. the body alone is the self. B. a hidden substance unifies the parts. C. "person" is a dependent designation upon an organized aggregate-stream. D. persons do not exist even conventionally.

Answer: C. "Person" is a dependent designation upon an organized aggregate-stream.

Explanation: The analogy rejects a separately findable substantial person while preserving conventional reference and practical agency. It is not eliminative nihilism.

15. How does dharma-nairātmya extend pudgala-nairātmya?

A. It restores a permanent self at the level of consciousness. B. It denies intrinsic self-nature not only in persons but also in constituent phenomena. C. It denies conventional persons but accepts eternal dharmas. D. It limits no-self to bodily form.

Answer: B. It denies intrinsic self-nature not only in persons but also in constituent phenomena.

Explanation: Personal no-self is shared broadly; Mahāyāna emphatically extends non-selfhood to dharmas. This prevents momentary elements from becoming replacement substances.

16. Which statement best reconciles Nirvāṇa with no-self?

A. Nirvāṇa destroys an actually existing eternal soul. B. An ātman temporarily disappears and later returns. C. Nirvāṇa is cessation of the causes of suffering within a causal stream, without an eternal owner. D. Nirvāṇa is the immortality of a purified ego.

Answer: C. Nirvāṇa is cessation of the causes of suffering within a causal stream, without an eternal owner.

Explanation: The practitioner and liberated continuum are causally related without being one immutable substance. No-self removes the appropriation that feeds craving rather than abolishing the path.

17. Vaibhāṣika is most accurately described as:

A. cognition-only idealism. B. universal emptiness of all dharmas. C. representational realism in which objects are only inferred. D. direct realism about external, momentary dharmas.

Answer: D. Direct realism about external, momentary dharmas.

Explanation: Vaibhāṣika treats external dharmas as real and directly perceived. It differs from Sautrāntika about epistemic access and from Mādhyamaka about ultimate status.

18. Sautrāntika differs from Vaibhāṣika chiefly because it holds that:

A. external objects are inferred from cognition's representations rather than directly perceived. B. only universals are causally efficient. C. consciousness is an eternal substance. D. no external objects exist.

Answer: A. External objects are inferred from cognition's representations rather than directly perceived.

Explanation: Sautrāntika remains realist but is representational or inferential in epistemology. The mental form is directly known; an external cause is inferred.

19. Which statement about Yogācāra is most accurate?

A. Yogācāra denies karma and intersubjective regularity. B. A private ego freely imagines whatever world it wants. C. *Vijñaptimātratā* denies independently established external objects while retaining a conditioned and ordered cognitive flow. D. Yogācāra is identical to Advaita because both use consciousness vocabulary.

Answer: C. Vijñaptimātratā denies independently established external objects while retaining a conditioned and ordered cognitive flow.

Explanation: Yogācāra is not whimsical subjective idealism. Karmic seeds and shared conditioning explain structured experience, while the subject-object split is analysed as constructed.

20. What is the main function of ālaya-vijñāna?

A. To serve as an eternal ātman. B. To carry karmic and cognitive seeds through a changing stream. C. To create matter ex nihilo. D. To guarantee knowledge of external substances.

Answer: B. To carry karmic and cognitive seeds through a changing stream.

Explanation: Store-consciousness explains continuity, memory and coordinated experience. Yogācāra insists that it too is conditioned and transformable, so treating it as a permanent self is a factual error.

21. In the tri-svabhāva, parikalpita refers to:

A. the dependently arisen cognitive flow. B. the imagined construction of independent subject-object duality. C. an eternal material substratum. D. the perfected realization of non-duality.

Answer: B. The imagined construction of independent subject-object duality.

Explanation: *Paratantra* is the dependent flow; *pariniṣpanna* is realization of the absence of the imagined duality. The three are analytical aspects, not three separate substances.

22. In the tri-svabhāva, paratantra is:

A. permanent pure consciousness. B. sheer non-being. C. the dependently arisen flow conditioned by causes and seeds. D. the external object as directly perceived.

Answer: C. The dependently arisen flow conditioned by causes and seeds.

Explanation: Yogācāra does not deny the causal process of cognition. It denies the independently real duality projected upon that dependent flow.

23. In the tri-svabhāva, pariniṣpanna is:

A. the independent existence of store-consciousness. B. the inference from a representation to matter. C. the persistence of subject-object duality at the ultimate level. D. perfected realization of the dependent flow's freedom from imagined duality.

Answer: D. Perfected realization of the dependent flow's freedom from imagined duality.

Explanation: The perfected nature is not another substance behind experience. It is the dependent nature correctly known as lacking the projected dual structure.

24. Which statement best expresses Mādhyamaka Śūnyatā?

A. Nothing exists or functions at any level. B. Phenomena lack intrinsic *svabhāva* while functioning conventionally through dependence. C. Empty things cannot enter causal relations. D. Only consciousness possesses ultimate being.

Answer: B. Phenomena lack intrinsic svabhāva while functioning conventionally through dependence.

Explanation: Emptiness is anti-essentialism, not nothingness. Dependent functioning and emptiness are mutually implicative: fixed essences would make change and causal interaction impossible.

25. Why does Mādhyamaka say that dependent origination implies emptiness?

A. What depends on causes and designation cannot possess independent own-nature. B. Dependence proves that only matter is real. C. Causal relations are logically impossible. D. Every effect must pre-exist in a permanent cause.

Answer: A. What depends on causes and designation cannot possess independent own-nature.

Explanation: *Svabhāva* would mean self-establishment. Dependence is therefore incompatible with intrinsic essence, though fully compatible with conventional existence.

26. The two truths are:

A. perception and inference. B. mind and matter. C. conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*) and ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*). D. permanence and annihilation.

Answer: C. Conventional truth (saṃvṛti-satya) and ultimate truth (paramārtha-satya).

Explanation: Conventionally, language, ethics and causation work; ultimately, no entity has independent *svabhāva*. The distinction prevents both reification and nihilism.

27. “Emptiness of emptiness” chiefly prevents:

A. ethical action. B. analysis of causal conditions. C. reification of Śūnyatā into a new Absolute. D. conventional discourse.

Answer: C. Reification of Śūnyatā into a new Absolute.

Explanation: Emptiness is itself dependently designated and has no own-nature. It is a therapeutic critique of essence, not an ultimate substance.

28. How can realist Buddhism and Mādhyamaka draw opposed conclusions from Pratītyasamutpāda?

A. Realists accept causation, whereas Mādhyamaka rejects it. B. Mādhyamaka accepts permanent substances, whereas realists reject them. C. Both use “real” and “empty” in exactly the same sense. D. Realists infer causal reality of conditioned dharmas; Mādhyamaka infers their lack of intrinsic nature.

Answer: D. Realists infer causal reality of conditioned dharmas; Mādhyamaka infers their lack of intrinsic nature.

Explanation: The positions partly answer different questions-whether phenomena function and whether they are self-grounded. A genuine dispute remains over whether momentary dharmas are ultimately real.

29. Which pramāṇas are fundamental for Dignāga and Dharmakīrti?

A. Perception, inference and testimony. B. Six independent pramāṇas. C. Perception, comparison, testimony and postulation. D. Perception and inference.

Answer: D. Perception and inference.

Explanation: Other apparently valid cognitions are reduced to these two. Perception concerns non-conceptual particulars; inference operates through conceptual construction.

30. Svalakṣaṇa is:

A. a unique causally efficient particular, the ultimate object of perception. B. an eternal universal known by language. C. the exclusion of non-cows. D. the conventional person.

Answer: A. A unique causally efficient particular, the ultimate object of perception.

Explanation: The momentary particular is directly efficacious and non-conceptual. A *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* is the generalized, conceptually constructed object used in thought and language.

31. Why is sāmānyalakṣaṇa associated with conceptual cognition?

A. It is an eternal self. B. It is an indivisible atom. C. It is a generalized construction rather than the unique particular given in bare perception. D. It alone produces causal effects.

Answer: C. It is a generalized construction rather than the unique particular given in bare perception.

Explanation: Concepts organize distinct particulars under repeatable types. Buddhist epistemologists deny that such universals exist as independently real entities.

32. Apoha explains word meaning primarily through:

A. direct contact with a real universal. B. resemblance to a permanent prototype. C. exclusion of what is other, such as “cow” functioning through exclusion of non-cows. D. divine assignment of meanings.

Answer: C. Exclusion of what is other, such as “cow” functioning through exclusion of non-cows.

Explanation: Because only unique particulars are ultimately real, repeatable linguistic classification cannot depend on eternal universals. Exclusion yields usable conceptual scope without reifying a universal.

33. Kumārila’s major objection to Apoha is that:

A. purely negative exclusion seems unable to explain the positive unity grasped in a word’s meaning. B. exclusion proves that universals are momentary. C. perception is always conceptual. D. words never produce cognition.

Answer: A. Purely negative exclusion seems unable to explain the positive unity grasped in a word's meaning.

Explanation: The Buddhist reply is that exclusions, grounded in causal similarities and practical purposes, generate a positive-seeming conceptual presentation without requiring a real universal.

34. In Buddhist epistemology, the contrast between *pramāṇa* and *pramāṇaphala* is best expressed as:

A. a cognition can be the knowing operation in one aspect and its successful apprehension in another, unlike Nyāya's strongly external instrument-result model. B. instrument and result must always be two enduring substances. C. valid cognition has no result. D. testimony alone joins the two.

Answer: A. A cognition can be the knowing operation in one aspect and its successful apprehension in another, unlike Nyāya's strongly external instrument-result model.

Explanation: Dignāga-Dharmakīrti resist multiplying separately enduring entities. The 2025 debate requires presenting this Buddhist reflexive or cognition-centred model against Nyāya's realist account.

35. Which is among the Buddha's *avyākṛta* questions?

A. Whether right action reduces suffering. B. Whether craving conditions clinging. C. Whether perception occurs. D. Whether the world is eternal or non-eternal.

Answer: D. Whether the world is eternal or non-eternal.

Explanation: Questions about the world's eternity/finitude, identity of soul and body, and the Tathāgata after death were left undeclared because their speculative framing did not conduce to liberation.

36. The best interpretation of the Buddha's silence on *avyākṛta* questions is:

A. pragmatic and therapeutic refusal of wrongly framed speculation irrelevant to ending *duḥkha*. B. denial that language has any use. C. proof that he secretly accepted every alternative. D. inability to reason about metaphysics.

Answer: A. Pragmatic and therapeutic refusal of wrongly framed speculation irrelevant to ending *duḥkha*.

Explanation: Silence is not automatically agnosticism or verificationism. It redirects inquiry toward causal conditions of suffering and may reject the presuppositions embedded in the alternatives.

37. The fire-going-out simile warns against asking where the liberated Tathāgata "goes" because:

A. Nirvāṇa is a physical location. B. fire is an eternal substance. C. "going somewhere" wrongly presupposes a substantial entity persisting independently of conditions. D. the Tathāgata becomes a creator.

Answer: C. "Going somewhere" wrongly presupposes a substantial entity persisting independently of conditions.

Explanation: When fuel ceases, fire is not properly described as travelling north or south. Likewise, post-mortem alternatives may import the substantial self that Buddhism rejects.

38. Which statement correctly relates the Triratna to *Nairātmyavāda*?

A. Refuge requires three eternal souls. B. Buddha is an unchanging creator. C. No-self makes teaching and community impossible. D. Buddha and Saṅgha are conventionally real causal persons/communities, while Dhamma includes insight into no-self.

Answer: D. Buddha and Saṅgha are conventionally real causal persons/communities, while Dhamma includes insight into no-self.

Explanation: Refuge is practical orientation within dependent relations, not interaction among immortal substances. Institutional and personal continuity need not be numerical identity.

39. Which pair correctly names the classical karmic objections?

A. *kṛtanāśa* (loss of the performed act) and *akṛtābhyāgama* (receipt of an unperformed result) B. *anvaya* and *vyatireka* C. *satkāryavāda* and *asatkāryavāda* D. *anyathākhyāti* and *akhyāti*

Answer: A. *Kṛtanāśa* (loss of the performed act) and *akṛtābhyāgama* (receipt of an unperformed result).

Explanation: Opponents argue that destruction of the agent loses desert, while a later different moment undeservedly receives the fruit. Buddhism replies through causal inheritance in one stream.

40. In a UPSC directive, “critically discuss” requires the candidate to:

A. define the doctrine and stop. B. explain the position, present objections and replies, assess residual difficulties, and reach a reasoned verdict. C. reject the doctrine in advance. D. list scholars without argument.

Answer: B. Explain the position, present objections and replies, assess residual difficulties, and reach a reasoned verdict.

Explanation: “Critically” does not mean hostile. A strong Philosophy answer follows claim -> named evidence or argument -> analysis -> qualification, then gives a proportionate conclusion.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS

41. Which ordering of the middle nidānas is correct?

A. *trṣṇā* -> *vedanā* -> *sparśa* -> *ṣaḍāyatana* B. *ṣaḍāyatana* -> *sparśa* -> *vedanā* -> *trṣṇā* C. *vedanā* -> *sparśa* -> *ṣaḍāyatana* -> *trṣṇā* D. *sparśa* -> *ṣaḍāyatana* -> *trṣṇā* -> *vedanā*

Answer: B. Ṣaḍāyatana -> sparśa -> vedanā -> trṣṇā.

Explanation: The six sense bases condition contact, contact feeling and feeling craving. This sequence is both a factual requirement and the basis for explaining mindful interruption before craving.

42. Which school-pairing is correct?

A. Vaibhāṣika-direct realism; Sautrāntika-representational realism. B. Vaibhāṣika-external objects merely inferred; Sautrāntika-direct realism. C. Sautrāntika-no external world; Yogācāra-direct realism. D. Yogācāra-material atomism; Mādhyamaka-eternal consciousness.

Answer: A. Vaibhāṣika-direct realism; Sautrāntika-representational realism.

Explanation: Both are realist about external particulars, but they disagree about access. Yogācāra challenges independent externality, while Mādhyamaka empties both object and cognition of *svabhāva*.

43. Which statement avoids the most common Śūnyatā trap?

A. “Void” means absolute non-being. B. Śūnyatā is an eternal metaphysical substance. C. Empty phenomena cannot cause anything. D. Emptiness denies intrinsic nature while dependent conventional functioning remains.

Answer: D. Emptiness denies intrinsic nature while dependent conventional functioning remains.

Explanation: Nāgārjuna’s point is that dependence and emptiness are inseparable. Nihilism would destroy the very causal and linguistic practices through which the doctrine is expressed.

44. Which statement best answers the charge that ālaya-vijñāna is a disguised ātman?

A. It is outside causation and never changes. B. It is a conditioned, momentary and transformable stream carrying seeds, not an independent owner. C. It is permanent but should not be called a self. D. It belongs only to matter.

Answer: B. It is a conditioned, momentary and transformable stream carrying seeds, not an independent owner.

Explanation: Functional continuity alone does not equal substancehood. The objection revives if store-consciousness is incorrectly made immutable, unitary and self-established.

45. Which answer spine is best for “How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda?”

A. Compare four Buddhist schools without showing any inference. B. List twelve links -> state that everything changes -> conclude. C. Discuss only Nirvāṇa and no-self. D. Define both -> derive impermanence from dependence -> add *arthakriyā* dilemma -> answer *sahakārin* -> explain *santāna* -> qualify the derivation.

Answer: D. Define both -> derive impermanence from dependence -> add arthakriyā dilemma -> answer sahakārin -> explain santāna -> qualify the derivation.

Explanation: The question tests derivation. A complete answer must expose the logical bridge and preserve continuity, not merely provide adjacent descriptions.

46. Which claim most accurately answers akṛtābhyāgama?

A. The later recipient is numerically identical in every respect to the earlier agent. B. The karmic fruit arises in the causally continuous stream shaped by the act, not in an unrelated series. C. Moral responsibility is an illusion. D. A creator reallocates karmic fruits.

Answer: B. The karmic fruit arises in the causally continuous stream shaped by the act, not in an unrelated series.

Explanation: Buddhism rejects both strict identity and absolute difference. The reply grounds desert in causal inheritance, though critics still question whether it fully explains ownership.

47. Which statement about Nirvāṇa and Kṣaṇikavāda is most precise?

A. Kṣaṇikavāda applies to conditioned entities; Nirvāṇa may be described as unconditioned or as cessation, without postulating an eternal person. B. Nirvāṇa is momentary pleasure. C. Momentariness logically rules out cessation. D. Nirvāṇa is a permanent personal experience and therefore an exception to all Buddhist analysis.

Answer: A. Kṣaṇikavāda applies to conditioned entities; Nirvāṇa may be described as unconditioned or as cessation, without postulating an eternal person.

Explanation: The compatibility depends on not substantializing Nirvāṇa. Finality means the non-renewal of suffering's conditions, not everlasting possession by an ego.

48. Which distinction is essential in answering the 2024 “everything is void/everything is real” PYQ?

A. Perception versus testimony. B. Causal/conventional reality versus intrinsic or self-established reality. C. Buddha versus Saṅgha. D. Bodily continuity versus memory.

Answer: B. Causal/conventional reality versus intrinsic or self-established reality.

Explanation: Realist schools affirm causally efficacious dharmas; Mādhyamaka denies their *svabhāva*. The distinction resolves superficial contradiction while retaining the deeper dispute about ultimate status.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQS - 13 COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Practice status: These are independently prepared learner models based on the verified UPSC questions in the repository. They are not official UPSC answer keys. Each answer should first be attempted under timed conditions and then used for comparison, correction and enrichment.

2018 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Explain the Mādhyamika inference from dependent origination to emptiness.
- Define *svabhāva* and show why dependence excludes it.
- Protect Śūnyatā from the charge of nihilism through the two truths.

Independent model answer

For Mādhyamika, *pratītyasamutpāda* means that every phenomenon arises only in dependence on causes, conditions, parts, relations and conceptual designation. Nāgārjuna uses this causal principle to deny *svabhāva*, an independent, self-established and invariant own-nature.

If a thing possessed *svabhāva*, it would exist through itself and would not await conditions. What depends upon conditions, however, is neither self-produced nor self-sufficient. Therefore:

dependent arising -> absence of independent own-nature -> ■■■nyat■

Śūnyatā consequently does not mean sheer non-being. A chariot, person or flame exists and functions conventionally, but none is discoverable as a self-grounded substance apart from its components and conditions. Indeed, causal efficacy is possible precisely because things are not fixed by immutable essence.

The doctrine of two truths blocks nihilism. At the level of *saṃvṛti-satya*, persons, causes, karma, language and compassion operate. At the level of *paramārtha-satya*, analysis finds no intrinsically existent entity. Even emptiness is empty: it is not a hidden Absolute but the absence of *svabhāva* in dependently designated things.

Thus Mādhyamika converts dependent origination into ontological anti-essentialism. “Whatever is dependently arisen is explained to be empty” affirms relational existence while rejecting independent essence.

Why this earns marks

- Gives the exact dependence-to-emptiness derivation.
- Defines *svabhāva* instead of treating Śūnyatā as a slogan.
- Uses a concrete conventional example.
- Employs the two truths against nihilism.
- Notes the “emptiness of emptiness” safeguard.

2018 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Demand decoding

- Test, rather than merely assert, the compatibility of no-self and liberation.
- Explain who practises and what ceases without postulating an eternal soul.
- Give reasons in favour while acknowledging the first-person identity objection.

Independent model answer

Nairātmyavāda denies a permanent, unitary and unchanging owner behind the five skandhas. *Nirvāṇa* is the cessation of ignorance, craving and the conditioned reproduction of suffering. They are consistent once liberation is understood as the transformation and cessation of a causal process, not as an eternal soul entering another substance or realm.

The empirical person is conventionally designated upon *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saṃjñā*, *saṃskāra* and *viññāna*. Ignorance superimposes “I” and “mine” upon this changing aggregate-stream. That appropriation produces craving, clinging and renewed becoming:

self-grasping -> craving -> clinging -> becoming -> suffering

Insight into impermanence and no-self removes the cognitive basis of appropriation:

insight into no-self -> non-grasping -> cessation -> nirvāṇa

The objection is immediate: if no self exists, nobody suffers, practises or attains liberation. The Buddhist reply invokes *santāna*, causal continuity. The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Ethical discipline and meditative cultivation alter succeeding moments just as one flame conditions another without a single enduring flame-substance.

Theravāda descriptions emphasize cessation of greed, hatred and delusion and may classify Nirvāṇa as *asaṃskṛta*, unconditioned. Mahāyāna adds that saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa are both empty of *svabhāva*: their distinction concerns ignorance and insight, not two self-existent domains.

A residual difficulty remains. Causal continuity explains transmission, but critics ask whether it fully explains the first-person claim “I am liberated.” Buddhism answers that this “I” is a conventional index within the stream, not evidence for an eternal ātman.

Therefore no-self is not an obstacle to Nirvāṇa; it is the insight that dissolves the grasping sustaining bondage.

Why this earns marks

- Defines both doctrines before testing consistency.
- Connects no-self directly to the causal production and cessation of duḥkha.
- Uses *santāna* to explain practice without a soul.
- Adds Theravāda-Mahāyāna nuance.

- States the strongest objection and offers a qualified verdict.

2019 · Q5(b) · 10 marks

Question: How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- Present arguments, not merely translate *vijñaptimātratā* as “mind-only.”
- Explain how Yogācāra preserves ordered experience.
- Avoid reducing the school to arbitrary subjective imagination.

Independent model answer

Yogācāra advances *vijñaptimātratā*: what is immediately given is cognition-as-presentation, not an independently established external object standing outside every cognitive condition. The experienced division between subject and object is itself a construction within consciousness.

The dream argument shows that a coherent spatial world, objects and an experiencing subject can appear without corresponding external things. Therefore object-appearance alone cannot establish an independently existing material cause. Yogācāra also attacks atomism: an object cannot coherently be one indivisible atom, a mere heap of partless atoms, or a whole distinct from its parts. Further, if both object and cognition are momentary, the object allegedly known has already ceased when cognition arises; only its presented form is available.

This is not the claim that an individual ego invents the world at will. *Ālaya-vijñāna*, store-consciousness, carries karmic *bīja* whose maturation produces regular and coordinated experience. The *tri-svabhāva* clarifies the analysis: *parikalpita* is imagined subject-object duality; *paratantra* is the dependently arisen cognitive flow; *pariṇiṣpanna* is realization of that flow’s non-dual character.

Yogācāra therefore denies the external world as independently established, not causal order or disciplined experience. Its difficulty is whether common experience can be explained without covertly restoring an object-independent world.

Why this earns marks

- States *vijñaptimātratā* precisely.
- Uses dream, atom and temporal arguments.
- Explains order through *ālaya-vijñāna* and karmic seeds.
- Includes all three natures.
- Ends with a genuine philosophical difficulty.

2019 · Q7(c) · 15 marks

Question: What is Pratītyasamutpāda? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?

Demand decoding

- Define dependent origination in general and existential forms.
- Show the logical bridge to *kṣaṇikavāda*.
- Include causal efficacy, apparent continuity and at least one objection.

Independent model answer

Pratītyasamutpāda is conditional arising: “this being, that arises; from the cessation of this, that ceases.” Existentially it appears in the twelve nidānas from *avidyā* to *jarā-maraṇa*; philosophically it denies that conditioned phenomena arise independently, eternally or without causes.

The immediate consequence is impermanence. Whatever depends on a changing complex of conditions cannot remain wholly unchanged. Buddhist logicians strengthen this into universal momentariness through *arthakriyākāritva*, the criterion of causal efficacy:

1. What is real is capable of producing an effect.
2. A permanent entity possesses the same causal capacity at every moment.

3. It should therefore produce its effect always, all at once, or never.
4. If it acts only when auxiliary conditions arrive, the altered causal complex-not an unchanged substance-explains the effect.
5. Causal operation thus belongs to a determinate, moment-specific particular.
6. Hence, *yaṭ sat tat kṣaṇikam*: whatever is causally real is momentary.

A seed, for example, is not one unchanged thing enduring through germination. It is a succession of causal phases, each producing a novel successor. Apparent endurance is *santāna*, a continuum of numerically distinct but causally connected events.

Nyāya objects that a permanent substance can possess stable power and act when *sahakārin* auxiliaries arrive. The Buddhist reply asks whether those auxiliaries alter the cause. If they do, strict permanence is abandoned; if they do not, the delayed effect remains unexplained.

Dependent origination by itself yields conditioned impermanence; joined to causal efficacy, it supports strict momentariness. Mādhyamika adds that momentary dharmas too are dependently arisen and must not be reified.

Why this earns marks

- Defines both the general formula and twelve-link context.
- Gives a stepwise *arthakriyā* proof.
- Explains continuity through *santāna*.
- Handles Nyāya's auxiliary-condition objection.
- Distinguishes impermanence from the stricter logical doctrine.

2020 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda in Buddhism? Explain.

Demand decoding

- Establish a rigorous derivation rather than placing two doctrines side by side.
- Explain *arthakriyākāritva*, simultaneity/succession and *sahakārin*.
- Address continuity, objections and the Mādhyamika refinement.

Independent model answer

Pratītyasamutpāda states that every conditioned phenomenon arises and ceases through a determinate complex of conditions. *Kṣaṇikavāda* radicalizes this into the thesis that every causally real conditioned entity exists for only a moment. The derivation proceeds through dependence, change and causal efficacy.

First, a self-existent permanent substance would not await conditions. Since conditioned phenomena arise only when causes converge and cease when those causes are absent, their existence is relational and alterable. Conditionality therefore excludes immutable self-subsistence.

Second, causal production marks a difference between phases. A seed capable of sprouting under one complex and no longer functioning as that seed after germination cannot be strictly identical before and after causal action. The effect is novel because the operative causal phase perishes in giving rise to its successor.

Third, Buddhist logicians formulate *arthakriyākāritva*: reality is capacity for effective causal operation. Suppose permanent X causes E. If X has its complete causal power, it should produce E immediately and, being unchanged, repeatedly or all effects simultaneously. If production is successive, X must have different operative powers at different times, contradicting permanence.

Nyāya answers that X waits for auxiliary conditions (*sahakārin*). The Buddhist dilemma is: if auxiliaries add no new capacity, delay remains inexplicable; if they alter the causal capacity, the operative complex is no longer wholly unchanged. Hence causal efficacy belongs to moment-specific particulars.

Momentariness does not entail disconnected flashes. *Santāna* is an ordered succession in which each moment transmits dispositions and causal powers to its successor. It explains the apparent continuity of flame, person, memory and karma without numerical identity. The later moment is neither identical with nor causally alien to the earlier one.

Two qualifications are needed. First, ordinary dependent origination directly establishes impermanence; strict one-moment duration depends on the additional arthakriyā argument. Second, Mādhyamika warns that momentary dharmas cannot replace permanent substances as new absolutes: because they too arise dependently, they are empty of *svabhāva*.

Thus Kṣaṇikavāda is a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda when conditional arising is interpreted through causal efficacy. Dependence removes permanence; arthakriyā locates reality in the perishing causal event; *santāna* preserves continuity.

Why this earns marks

- Builds the derivation in distinct logical stages.
- Uses the simultaneity/succession dilemma correctly.
- Engages Nyāya's named *sahakārin* reply.
- Explains continuity rather than confusing momentariness with chaos.
- Adds both the "extra premise" qualification and Mādhyamika correction.
- Concludes with a precise synthesis.

2020 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?

Demand decoding

- Name and explain the five aggregates.
- Distinguish conventional personhood from a substantial self.
- Explain liberation positively and answer the "who is liberated?" objection.

Independent model answer

Buddhism analyses the apparent self into five aggregates (*pañcaskandhas*): *rūpa* or material form; *vedanā* or feeling-tone; *saṃjñā* or recognition; *saṃskāra* or volitional formations; and *vijñāna* or discriminative consciousness. Every candidate is conditioned, changing and not fully controllable. No permanent owner is found as one aggregate, their sum, or an entity outside them.

The *Milinda-pañha* chariot analogy expresses the positive position. "Chariot" is a conventional designation for suitably arranged parts; similarly, "person" names an organized psycho-physical causal stream. Buddhism therefore rejects an eternal ātman but not the conventional person who speaks, acts and undertakes discipline.

Liberation is *Nirvāṇa*: the cessation of *avidyā*, craving, clinging and the renewed production of *duḥkha*. The Noble Eightfold Path works upon the aggregate-stream. *Śīla* prevents harmful conditioning, *saṃādhi* disciplines attention and *prajñā* sees impermanence, suffering and no-self. Liberation is not the survival or annihilation of a soul; it is the ending of the processes that construct bondage.

The objection asks who receives the fruit if the practitioner constantly changes. Buddhism answers through *santāna*. The later liberated stream inherits the effects of earlier practice without being an unchanging substance. Causal continuity is sufficient for transformation just as education changes a child into an adult without requiring an immutable psychological core.

Thus aggregate analysis removes the imagined owner, while liberation removes the causes of appropriation. No-self is not a denial of the path's subject at the conventional level; it is its liberating insight.

Why this earns marks

- Correctly names and explains all five skandhas.
- Uses the chariot analogy without denying conventional persons.
- Defines Nirvāṇa through causal cessation and the Eightfold Path.
- Answers the agency/recipient objection with *santāna*.
- Avoids both eternalism and annihilationism.

2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda and dharma-nairātmyavāda with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.

Demand decoding

- Identify the precise object denied by each doctrine.
- Locate the distinction across early/Abhidharma and Mahāyāna tendencies.
- Explain why denying only the personal self may leave reified dharmas.

Independent model answer

Both doctrines express no-self, but their scope differs.

Doctrine	Object of denial	Positive implication	Typical emphasis
<i>Pudgala-nairātmya</i>	a permanent person or owner of the aggregates	person is conventionally designated upon a causal stream	broadly shared across Buddhism
<i>Dharma-nairātmya</i>	intrinsic self-nature in the constituent dharmas themselves	all phenomena are dependent and non-self-grounded	especially Mahāyāna

Pudgala-nairātmya analyses the person into the five skandhas and finds no independent *pudgala* as one of them, their sum or their possessor. It denies ātman while retaining conventional agency and causal continuity.

Some Abhidharma realist positions nevertheless treat momentary dharmas as ultimately real. *Dharma-nairātmya* extends the analysis: the supposed building blocks also lack *svabhāva*. Mādhyamika derives this from dependent origination; Yogācāra associates it with freedom from constructed subject-object duality.

The second doctrine prevents the critique of a substantial person from ending in a metaphysics of substantial atoms. Yet it does not mean that phenomena are nothing; it denies independent essence while preserving conventional causal functioning.

Why this earns marks

- Distinguishes the two doctrines by exact scope.
- Shows what remains conventionally valid.
- Locates Mahāyāna's extension without claiming earlier Buddhism accepted ātman.
- Explains the anti-reification purpose of *dharma-nairātmya*.
- Avoids equating emptiness with non-existence.

2021 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Explain the apparent contradiction between momentariness and memory.
- Present stream, trace/seed and Yogācāra mechanisms.
- Evaluate Nyāya's first-person ownership objection.

Independent model answer

Kṣaṇikavāda appears to make memory impossible. The moment that experienced an object has ceased before the remembering cognition arises; if the two moments are wholly different, how can the later one remember "I experienced this"?

Buddhism replaces substantial identity with *santāna*, a causally integrated continuum. An experience conditions its successor by leaving a disposition; the disposition is transmitted through later moments and, when suitable conditions arise, produces memory:

experience -> impression -> transmitted potency -> occasioning condition -> memory

Sautrāntika speaks of seeds or latent traces in the mental continuum. Yogācāra gives a more systematic account through *ālaya-vijñāna*, whose *bīja* preserve mnemonic and karmic potentials. Personal identity is therefore

conventional continuity constituted by causal connection, bodily organization, resemblance, projects and inherited dispositions.

The later rememberer is neither strictly identical with nor wholly other than the earlier experiencer. Strict numerical identity would reintroduce an immutable ātman; absolute difference would generate the faults of lost action and unearned result. Buddhism adopts a middle relation of causal succession.

Nyāya's *pratyabhijñā* and memory objection remains powerful. Cognitions such as "this is that" and "I saw this" seem to presuppose one enduring subject that unifies past and present. Mere resemblance can explain similar content but perhaps not first-person ownership. The Buddhist replies that the "I" is itself a concept generated within an integrated stream: direct causal inheritance, not metaphysical substance, grounds appropriation.

This reply successfully explains information transmission and practical identity, much as ordinary law follows a changing person through time. Yet if first-person unity is regarded as irreducible, *santāna* may seem descriptive rather than fully explanatory.

Hence Buddhism offers a coherent process account of memory and identity, though the move from causal continuity to owned recollection remains philosophically contestable.

Why this earns marks

- Frames the exact temporal problem.
- Gives both Sautrāntika and Yogācāra continuity mechanisms.
- Uses the neither-identical-nor-wholly-different formula.
- Names Nyāya's recognition/ownership pressure.
- Distinguishes successful transmission from disputed first-person appropriation.

2022 · Q6(a) · 20 marks

Question: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Reconcile delayed karmic fruit with the destruction of every moment.
- Name classical objections and school-specific Buddhist mechanisms.
- Critically test whether causation is enough for moral ownership.

Independent model answer

Karma connects intentional action with a later fruit; Kṣaṇikavāda denies any enduring agent that remains numerically identical from action to fruition. Their compatibility therefore depends on whether moral responsibility requires substance-identity or only appropriately ordered causal continuity.

Buddhism chooses the latter:

intention -> karmic impression/potency -> transmission in *santāna* -> maturation -> fruit

The act perishes, but not without causally modifying the stream. Sautrāntika explains the connection through seed-like potency; Yogācāra places karmic *bīja* in *ālaya-vijñāna*; Abhidharma traditions analyse multiple causal relations among successive dharmas. None requires an unchanging bearer.

Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā and Vedānta press three related objections. First, *kṛtanāśa*: because the doer perishes, the deed and its desert are lost. Second, *akṛtābhyāgama*: a later, numerically different moment receives the fruit of an act it did not perform. Third, praise, blame, recognition and remorse appear to presuppose one owner across time.

The Buddhist reply rejects the exhaustive choice between absolute identity and absolute difference. The fruit occurs in the very continuum causally formed by the action, not in an unrelated stream. A child and adult are neither qualitatively unchanged nor morally unrelated; responsibility normally tracks continuity of body, intention, memory and causal history rather than an empirically inaccessible ātman.

The objection that a momentary cause cannot yield a remote result is answered by serial transmission. Each moment immediately conditions the next, carrying transformed potency until supporting conditions permit maturation. A seed

need not remain numerically present in the fruit; its causal influence persists through the series.

Nevertheless, two pressures remain. Causal explanation shows why B follows A more readily than why B's suffering is deserved as *my* fruit. Further, *ālaya-vijñāna* can appear to function like a disguised self if treated as a persistent substance. Yogācāra replies that the store-consciousness is itself momentary and transformable; Mādhyamaka adds that agent, act and fruit are conventionally dependent designations, not ultimate substances.

Karma and momentariness are therefore compatible within Buddhist process ontology. The account is strong against the demand for numerical identity, but its reduction of moral ownership to causal inheritance remains open to realist criticism.

Why this earns marks

- States the exact compatibility criterion.
- Explains Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Abhidharma mechanisms.
- Names *kṛtanāśa* and *akṛtābhyāgama* accurately.
- Answers both delayed fruition and personal ownership objections.
- Critically tests whether *ālaya-vijñāna* becomes a quasi-self.
- Ends with a balanced verdict rather than a doctrinal assertion.

2022 · Q7(b) · 15 marks

Question: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).

Demand decoding

- Define Buddha, Dhamma and Saṅgha.
- Explain their internal, functional relation.
- Examine whether refuge, community and awakening require enduring selves.

Independent model answer

The *Triratna*-Buddha, Dhamma and Saṅgha-are the three refuges structuring Buddhist life. Buddha is the awakened teacher and exemplar; Dhamma is the truth of dependent origination, the diagnosis of suffering and the path to cessation; Saṅgha is the community that preserves, interprets and embodies that path.

Their relation is internal rather than additive. Buddha discovers and teaches Dhamma; Dhamma explains Buddha's awakening and makes its replication possible; Saṅgha transmits and practises Dhamma, producing further exemplars and sustaining access to the Buddha's teaching. Remove any one and the living refuge-system is impaired.

At first sight, *nairātmyavāda* creates inconsistency. Refuge seems to require a stable devotee, Buddha appears to be an enduring personal authority, and Saṅgha a collection of persons. Buddhism answers by distinguishing conventional personhood from an eternal ātman. Buddha is revered as an awakened causal continuum, not as creator or immortal soul. Saṅgha is a conventionally real community constituted by changing practitioners. Dhamma itself includes insight into no-self.

The two truths deepen this reply. Conventionally, teachers, vows, institutions and agents operate; ultimately, none possesses independent self-nature. No-self therefore regulates the meaning of refuge: it is practical orientation and transformative dependence, not surrender by one immortal substance to another.

A critic may reply that continuity of doctrine and authority still requires stable bearers. The Buddhist response is that transmission needs reliable causal and institutional continuity, not numerical identity. Manuscripts, practices and lineages persist as changing but connected series.

Thus Triratna and no-soul are consistent. Indeed, the three refuges provide the pedagogic and communal conditions through which attachment to substantial selfhood is overcome.

Why this earns marks

- Defines all three jewels.
- Shows their reciprocal functional relation.
- Distinguishes conventional agents from an eternal soul.

- Uses the two truths without making Saṅgha unreal.
- Addresses continuity of authority and ends with an integrative verdict.

2023 · Q8(a) · 20 marks

Question: "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.

Demand decoding

- Organize Buddhist soteriology around the quotation.
- Connect the Four Noble Truths, twelve nidānas and Eightfold Path.
- Explain why transformative knowledge, not mere information, brings cessation.

Independent model answer

Buddhist soteriology begins from the Four Noble Truths: duḥkha, its dependent origin, its cessation and the path. The quotation condenses this structure. Ignorance of dependent origination is not a mere absence of theoretical information; *avidyā* is the practical misperception of conditioned, impermanent and selfless processes as permanent, satisfactory and owned by an "I."

The twelve nidānas display suffering as a conditioned circuit:

avidyā → saṃskāra → vijñāna → nāma-rūpa → āśayātana → sparśa → vedanā → tṛṣṇā → upādāna → bhava → jāti → jarā-maraṇa

Ignorance conditions formations and an appropriative mode of consciousness. Contact and feeling become craving; craving becomes clinging and renewed becoming. Thus suffering is not imposed by fate or God. It is continuously produced when supporting conditions operate.

Knowledge of dependent origination discloses three features: impermanence, absence of autonomous essence, and the interruptibility of causal processes. Feeling need not become craving; craving need not become clinging. Wisdom removes the false owner, while disciplined conduct and meditation transform the conditions under which reactions arise.

The Noble Eightfold Path embodies this knowledge. *Prajñā*-right view and resolve-understands dependence and no-self. *Śīla*-right speech, action and livelihood-prevents fresh harmful conditioning. *Samādhi*-right effort, mindfulness and concentration-reveals feeling before it hardens into craving and stabilizes non-grasping awareness.

Different schools refine the same soteriological grammar. Abhidharma analyses the stream into conditioned dharmas; Yogācāra purifies karmic seeds and the subject-object construction; Mādhyamaka realizes that dependently originated phenomena are empty of *svabhāva*, preventing attachment even to dharmas, doctrine or Nirvāṇa.

The statement should not be intellectualized. One may recite the twelve links while continuing to crave. Liberating knowledge is cultivated insight that restructures perception, affect and conduct. Nor does cessation imply annihilation of a self; it is cessation of the conditions reproducing duḥkha.

Therefore ignorance is suffering because it sustains appropriation within the dependent chain. Knowledge is cessation when it becomes the lived path by which those conditions are understood, weakened and finally extinguished.

Why this earns marks

- Makes the quotation the organizing thesis.
- Integrates Four Noble Truths, all twelve links and the Eightfold Path.
- Identifies practical intervention at feeling-craving-clinging.
- Adds Abhidharma, Yogācāra and Mādhyamaka nuances.
- Distinguishes transformative wisdom from verbal knowledge.
- Explains cessation without annihilationism.

2024 · Q6(b) · 15 marks

Question: How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of Pratītyasamutpāda? Answer with arguments.

Demand decoding

- Identify the realist and emptiness-oriented schools.
- Show how the same premise yields different conclusions.
- Distinguish causal reality from intrinsic reality without erasing disagreement.

Independent model answer

The apparent opposition arises because Buddhist schools ask different ontological questions of *pratītyasamutpāda*.

For Vaibhāṣika-and, with an epistemic qualification, Sautrāntika-dependent origination confirms the reality of conditioned dharmas. What enters causal relations and performs *arthakriyā* cannot be sheer illusion. Vaibhāṣika treats external momentary dharmas as directly perceived; Sautrāntika accepts external particulars but holds that they are known inferentially through mental representations. “Everything is real” therefore means that causally efficacious conditioned particulars are real, not that they are permanent substances.

Mādhyamika draws a different inference. Whatever arises only through causes and conditions lacks independent *svabhāva*. To possess own-nature would be to exist self-sufficiently and not dependently. Therefore all dharmas are *śūnya*. “Everything is void” means empty of intrinsic nature, not non-existent or causally inert.

Shared premise	Realist conclusion	Mādhyamika conclusion
phenomena arise through conditions	causal efficacy establishes conditioned reality	dependence disproves self-existence
permanent substance is rejected	momentary dharmas remain ultimately real	even momentary dharmas lack <i>svabhāva</i>
ordinary causation works	because real particulars interact	because conventionally designated relations function

The opposition is partly verbal: “real” answers whether phenomena causally function, while “void” answers whether they are intrinsically grounded. Yet a genuine dispute remains. Abhidharma realism grants ultimate status to basic dharmas; Mādhyamika argues that doing so arrests analysis too early and reifies the conditioned.

The two truths preserve the Mādhyamika position from nihilism: causation and karma operate conventionally, while ultimately no entity is self-established. Thus the same doctrine supports realism about dependent functioning and emptiness regarding independent essence.

Why this earns marks

- Correctly identifies Vaibhāṣika/Sautrāntika and Mādhyamika.
- Derives both conclusions from one premise.
- Distinguishes direct from representational realism.
- Separates causal efficacy from *svabhāva*.
- Preserves both partial reconciliation and genuine doctrinal disagreement.

2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks

Question: Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding

- Test Nirvāṇa separately against momentariness and no-self.
- Address conditioned/unconditioned and “who attains?” objections.
- Include a Mādhyamika qualification and a balanced verdict.

Independent model answer

Nirvāṇa is consonant with Kṣaṇikavāda and Nairātmyavāda if it is understood as cessation of the causes of suffering, not as an eternal soul entering a permanent condition.

Kṣaṇikavāda applies to conditioned entities: whatever arises through causes is momentary. This makes cessation intelligible, for a conditioned series continues only while its supports remain. Through the path, ignorance, craving and clinging cease to condition renewed becoming. Some traditions describe Nirvāṇa as *asaṃskṛta*, unconditioned; others emphasize the event or fact of cessation rather than a positive timeless substance.

Nairātmyavāda likewise poses no necessary contradiction. The person who practises is a conventional aggregate-stream. Earlier discipline causally transforms later moments; no immutable owner is needed. Nirvāṇa is neither the immortality nor the destruction of an ātman, because no such entity was admitted.

Opponents formulate a dilemma. If Nirvāṇa is permanent and real, does it violate momentariness? If momentary, how can liberation be final? If there is no self, who attains it? Buddhism replies that finality means non-renewal of the relevant conditions, not everlasting endurance of a personal state. Kṣaṇikavāda governs produced dharmas, while cessation is not another produced ego-experience.

Mādhyamika adds an anti-reification safeguard. Saṃsāra and Nirvāṇa are both empty of *svabhāva*; they are not two independent realms. Their distinction concerns bondage through ignorance and freedom through insight at the conventional level.

Tension remains where Nirvāṇa is treated as a positively existent eternal entity, or where first-person liberation is assumed to require numerical identity. Process interpretations avoid both assumptions, though critics may find them too deflationary.

Therefore the three doctrines are broadly consonant: momentariness explains the cessability of conditioned suffering, and no-self removes the grasping that sustains it. Consistency depends on refusing to substantialize either the liberated person or Nirvāṇa.

Why this earns marks

- Tests both requested doctrines independently.
- Distinguishes conditioned momentariness from unconditioned cessation.
- Answers the permanent/momentary and “who attains?” dilemmas.
- Adds the Mādhyamika non-reification account.
- Identifies the precise interpretive condition of compatibility.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why Pratītyasamutpāda is simultaneously a theory of causation and a method of liberation.

Demand decoding

- Establish the unity of explanatory and soteriological functions.
- Identify how the causal chain can be interrupted.
- Avoid treating dependent origination as neutral cosmology.

Independent model answer

Pratītyasamutpāda states that conditioned events arise and cease with their supporting conditions. It is therefore a theory of causation: duḥkha is neither accidental nor divinely imposed, but produced through an intelligible sequence of ignorance, formations, feeling, craving, clinging and becoming.

The same principle is a method of liberation because conditions are alterable. The chain is not fate:

contact -> feeling -> craving -> clinging -> becoming

Mindfulness can disclose feeling before it becomes craving; wisdom sees the experience as impermanent and non-self; ethical discipline prevents fresh harmful conditioning. When ignorance and craving cease, the dependent production of suffering also ceases.

The Four Noble Truths express this unity. The second truth diagnoses conditioned origin; the third affirms cessation; the fourth prescribes the practices that transform the conditions. Knowledge must therefore be practical and cultivated, not merely verbal.

Verdict: Pratītyasamutpāda is liberating precisely because it is causal. By explaining how suffering is made, it shows how suffering can be unmade.

Why this earns marks

- Answers both halves through one principle.

- Identifies a concrete intervention point.
- Links the doctrine with the Four Noble Truths.
- Distinguishes transformative from merely propositional knowledge.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Distinguish the Buddhist denial of ātman from the denial of causal and conventional personhood.

Demand decoding

- Prevent the common inference from no-self to no person or no responsibility.
- Use aggregates, designation and *santāna*.
- State the residual philosophical issue briefly.

Independent model answer

Nairātmavāda denies an eternal, unitary and independently existing ātman; it does not deny every legitimate use of “person.” Aggregate analysis finds only *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saṃjñā*, *saṃskāra* and *viññāna*, none of which is permanent or an owner of the rest.

The chariot analogy shows the positive account. A chariot is designated upon organized parts; a person is designated upon an organized psycho-physical stream. This conventional person acts, remembers, undertakes the path and bears consequences.

Causal continuity is explained through *santāna*. An earlier intention modifies succeeding moments, so the later recipient is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier agent. No-self therefore rejects substance-identity, not continuity, agency or moral practice.

The main objection is that causal connection may not fully explain first-person ownership-why a later memory or karmic fruit is *mine*. Buddhism replies that “mine” is itself constructed within the integrated stream.

Verdict: Buddhist no-self is a revision of personal identity from substance to dependent process, not the elimination of practical personhood.

Why this earns marks

- States exactly what is denied and retained.
- Uses both five-skandha analysis and the chariot analogy.
- Explains responsibility through *santāna*.
- Includes a concise critical qualification.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Compare Vaibhāṣika, Sautrāntika, Yogācāra and Mādhyamaka as four answers to the problem of the object of knowledge.

Demand decoding

- Compare all four schools on one epistemic-ontological axis.
- Show the movement from direct object to critique of both object and consciousness.
- Give strengths, pressures and a qualified verdict.

Independent model answer

The four schools offer progressively different answers to what cognition knows and what status its object possesses.

School	Object position	Mode of access	Main pressure
Vaibhāṣika	external momentary dharmas are real	directly perceived	how can a momentary object be simultaneously present to cognition?
Sautrāntika	external particulars are real	inferred from mental representations	how can a known representation prove an unknown original?
Yogācāra	independently external object is unestablished	cognition presents both subject and object	how is intersubjective order explained?

School	Object position	Mode of access	Main pressure
Mādhya maka	both mind and object lack <i>svabhāva</i>	knowledge operates conventionally	does universal emptiness undermine its own claim?

Vaibhāṣika protects common-sense causal realism: perception reaches real external dharmas. Sautrāntika recognizes temporal and cognitive mediation; the directly given item is a mental form whose external cause is inferred.

Yogācāra radicalizes the problem through *vijñaptimātratā*. Dream and atom arguments challenge an object existing independently of presentation. *Ālaya-vijñāna* and karmic seeds explain ordered experience; this is not arbitrary private imagination.

Mādhyaṃaka then warns that making consciousness ultimate merely shifts reification from object to subject. Because both arise dependently, neither has self-established nature. The two truths preserve conventional inquiry while ultimate analysis removes intrinsic essence.

The sequence is not a simple historical ladder. Vaibhāṣika best protects direct causal realism; Sautrāntika explains mediation; Yogācāra exposes cognitive construction; Mādhyaṃaka gives the widest anti-essentialist critique. Each solves one pressure by creating another.

Verdict: The debate moves from “Which object is known?” to “Can knower or known be intrinsically grounded?” Mādhyaṃaka is the most radical answer, but it remains viable only if conventional truth genuinely supports knowledge and argument.

Why this earns marks

- Compares all four schools through a common matrix.
- Preserves direct versus representational realism.
- Explains rather than caricatures *vijñaptimātratā*.
- Shows why Mādhyaṃaka also empties consciousness.
- Evaluates each position and reaches a qualified verdict.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Does the Buddhist theory of Apoha successfully explain general words without admitting real universals? Discuss.

Demand decoding

- State why Buddhist nominalism needs Apoha.
- Present its mechanism, named objection and Buddhist reply.
- Assess semantic success separately from ontological economy.

Independent model answer

Dignāga and Dharmakīrti distinguish the unique, causally efficient *svalakṣaṇa* from the generalized *sāmānyalakṣaṇa* constructed by thought. If only momentary particulars are ultimately real, a word such as “cow” cannot refer to one eternal universal present in many individuals. Apoha explains its extension through “exclusion of the other”: “cow” applies by excluding non-cows.

The theory is not bare negation. Repeated encounters generate dispositions; relevant causal similarities and human purposes stabilize a field of exclusions. These exclusions produce a positive-seeming conceptual presentation adequate for recognition, inference and communication, without postulating an independently existing cow-universal.

Kumārila Bhaṭṭa and Uddyotakara object that exclusion presupposes what it seeks to explain. To know “non-cow,” one must already know cow; moreover, a merely negative operation seems unable to yield the positive unity conveyed by a word. Different non-cows are indefinitely many, so their exclusion appears cognitively cumbersome.

The Buddhist reply distinguishes causal acquisition from philosophical analysis. Linguistic competence develops through practices of differentiation, not prior apprehension of a metaphysical universal. Mutual exclusions can generate a stable conceptual image, and practical success-not correspondence with an eternal entity-is the test of semantic adequacy.

Yet the objection is not fully dissolved. Apoha economically explains classification without realism about universals, but the positive phenomenology of meaning may be redescribed rather than completely derived from negation.

Verdict: Apoha is ontologically parsimonious and pragmatically powerful. Its weakness lies less in reference to particulars than in explaining how differential exclusion acquires the experienced positive unity of a concept.

Why this earns marks

- Grounds Apoha in the *svalakṣaṇa-sāmānyalakṣaṇa* distinction.
- Gives a clear example.
- Names Kumārila and Uddyotakara's objections.
- Presents the Buddhist practice-and-exclusion reply.
- Separates ontological economy from semantic completeness.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Buddhist process ontology secures change more successfully than it secures moral responsibility." Critically examine.

Demand decoding

- Test both parts of the proposition.
- Use dependent origination, momentariness, no-self and school-specific continuity devices.
- Assess whether causal succession can ground ownership and desert.

Independent model answer

Buddhist process ontology replaces enduring substance with dependent events. Its account of change is powerful because change is no longer an accidental modification of something fundamentally immutable; it is the very mode of conditioned existence.

Pratītyasamutpāda explains novelty through changing causal complexes. Kṣaṇikavāda sharpens this through *arthakriyākāritva*: the real is what performs a causal function, and a wholly permanent entity cannot explain delayed or successive effects. Nairātmyavāda extends the process model to persons, analysing them into changing skandhas rather than an invariant owner. The flame and seed series show how ordered transformation requires continuity but not numerical sameness.

Moral responsibility is harder. Karma connects an intention with a later fruit, but the acting moment has perished. Buddhism answers through *santāna*:

intention -> impression/potency -> serial transmission -> maturation -> fruit

Sautrāntika speaks of seeds in the continuum; Yogācāra uses *ālaya-vijñāna*; Abhidharma maps causal relations among dharmas. The later recipient is neither identical with nor unrelated to the earlier agent.

This answer defeats a crude objection. Ordinary responsibility already survives major bodily and psychological change. A mature adult may answer for a childhood promise because causal history, memory, intention and social continuity connect the phases. Numerical identity of an unobservable soul appears unnecessary.

Opponents nevertheless formulate *kṛtanāśa*: the destroyed doer loses the deed, and *akṛtābhyāgama*: a different successor receives an unperformed result. Nyāya adds that remorse and "I did this" contain first-person ownership that resemblance and succession do not explain. Causal continuity tells us why B follows A, but perhaps not why B deserves A's fruit.

The Buddhist reply is that desert supervenes on intentional causal inheritance within one stream. The "owner" adds no explanatory work unless its interaction with changing mental states is shown. Mādhyamaka further treats agent, act and fruit as conventionally dependent; morality needs stable practices, not ultimate substances.

Still, two risks remain. *Ālaya-vijñāna* may look like a quasi-self if reified, and reducing ownership to causal linkage may not satisfy those who regard first-person unity as irreducible. Yogācāra answers the first by making store-consciousness momentary and transformable; the second remains a genuine philosophical dispute.

Verdict: Buddhism explains change more naturally than substance theories because causal novelty is basic rather than derivative. Its account of responsibility is coherent and practically adequate, but less decisive: causal inheritance

plausibly grounds accountability, yet the transition from succession to first-person moral ownership remains contested.

Why this earns marks

- Evaluates both change and responsibility rather than discussing karma alone.
- Integrates Pratītyasamutpāda, *arthakriyā*, no-self and *santāna*.
- Uses Sautrāntika, Yogācāra, Abhidharma and Mādhyamaka refinements.
- Names and answers *kṛtanāśa* and *akṛtābhyāgama*.
- Distinguishes causal transmission from moral ownership.
- Ends with a measured, examiner-grade verdict.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: “Mādhyamaka avoids nihilism only by preserving the authority of conventional truth.” Examine with reference to Pratītyasamutpāda, the two truths and the emptiness of emptiness.

Demand decoding

- Explain why Śūnyatā attracts the nihilism charge.
- Show how dependence, two truths and reflexive emptiness answer it.
- Test whether conventional truth is merely expedient or philosophically indispensable.

Independent model answer

Mādhyamaka holds that all phenomena are empty of *svabhāva*. The charge of nihilism arises because, if nothing possesses intrinsic nature, causation, knowledge, ethics and liberation may seem impossible. Nāgārjuna’s answer is not to dilute emptiness but to show that conventional truth is the very field in which empty phenomena function.

Pratītyasamutpāda provides the first defence. A cause produces an effect only through relations and changing conditions. If either possessed fixed, independent own-nature, genuine interaction and transformation would be unintelligible. Emptiness therefore does not negate causation; it explains its possibility:

dependence -> absence of self-establishment -> relational efficacy

The two truths articulate this insight. At *saṃvṛti-satya*, persons deliberate, words refer, reasons support conclusions, karma bears fruit and the path ends suffering. At *paramārtha-satya*, analysis finds no independently existing agent, word, reason or dharma. Ultimate truth is not a second world behind convention; it is the absence of intrinsic nature in the conventional world.

The nihilist objection may persist: if conventional truth is itself empty, why trust it? Mādhyamaka replies that validity need not mean self-grounding. A map can guide without containing an intrinsic “map essence”; similarly, conventions are evaluated through coherence, dependence and practical success. The distinction between valid convention and hallucination remains internal to causal practices.

“Emptiness of emptiness” supplies the reflexive safeguard. Śūnyatā is not an Absolute that survives the deconstruction of all else. It too is dependently designated as a corrective to reification. Once its therapeutic work is done, it cannot be grasped as a metaphysical foundation.

Realists such as Nyāya object that this position borrows logic and causation while denying the stable entities required for them. If every thesis is empty, the thesis of emptiness appears self-refuting. Mādhyamaka answers that argument does not require intrinsically existent premises; conventional relations of entailment suffice. The critique targets the opponent’s claim of self-existence without proposing a rival essence.

However, conventional truth is not a dispensable ladder. Without its authority, there could be no teaching of emptiness, differentiation of wholesome from unwholesome, or path to Nirvāṇa. Mādhyamaka must therefore preserve a robust, though non-ultimate, account of warranted convention. If “conventional” is reduced to whatever appears, nihilism returns.

Verdict: Mādhyamaka avoids nihilism because emptiness and convention are mutually dependent: emptiness prevents reification, while convention preserves causation, rational assessment and liberation. The emptiness of emptiness completes the anti-essentialist logic, but the school’s success depends upon making conventional validity more than mere illusion.

Why this earns marks

- Frames the strongest nihilist and self-refutation objections.
- Derives emptiness from dependent origination.
- Explains both truths without turning them into two worlds.
- Uses “emptiness of emptiness” as a reflexive safeguard.
- Shows why conventional standards remain indispensable.
- Gives a qualified verdict identifying the doctrine’s precise burden.